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BATR. 240: TOWARD THE STYLISTIC ANALYSIS OF THE *BATRACHOMYOMACHIA*

Batrachomyomachia 240 reads as follows:

κείμενον ἐν δαπέδῳ λίθον ὄβριμον, ἄχθος ἀρούρης

Ludwich, in his commentary ad loc.,[1]) adduces the following two Homeric comparanda: *Od.* 9.305, with the phrase λίθον ὄβριμον, and *Il.* 18.104, with the phrase ἄχθος ἀρούρης. But there is much more we can say about the Homeric background of *Batr.* 240, speaking purely in terms of meter and formula.

Consider first the phrase ἄχθος ἀρούρης. Ludwich in fact cites the entire line *Il.* 18.104, in which ἄχθος ἀρούρης appears in final position; the metrical and phraseological correspondence with *Batr.* 240 is therefore evident.[2]) It is interesting to note, however, that five of the six occurrences of ἄχθος in Homer appear precisely in the metrical position ἄχθος ∪ – ⏑ # : in addition to the two instances of ἄχθος ἀρούρης # just cited, note ἄχθος ἐπείγει # *Il.* 12.452, ἄχθος ἄροιτο # *Il.* 20.247, ἄχθος ἄειραν # *Od.* 3.312. (I return to the sixth Homeric occurrence of ἄχθος below.)

Similarly, Ludwich cites the first four words of *Od.* 9.305 (# χερσὶν ἀπώσασθαι λίθον ὄβριμον), which allows us to see that λίθον ὄβριμον in *Batr.* 240 appears in the same position in the line. But again, this is not an isolated fact, but part of a larger network of correspondences: note the position of λίθον in *Il.* 7.264 ἀλλ' ἀναχασσάμενος λίθον εἵλετο χειρὶ παχείῃ, with the variant ἡ δ' ἀναχασσαμένη λίθον εἵλετο χειρὶ παχείῃ at *Il.* 21.403. Both of these lines, significantly, are followed by an identical line that begins # κείμενον ἐν πεδίῳ.

As for the # κείμενον ἐν δαπέδῳ of *Batr.* 240[3]): the same line-initial phrase appears in *Od.* 11.577; cf. *Od.* 22.188 # κουρίξ, ἐν δαπέδῳ and *Il.* 4.2 # χρυσέῳ ἐν δαπέδῳ, both with ἐν δαπέδῳ in the same metrical position, and further *Od.* 4.627 = 17.169 # ἐν τυκτῷ δαπέδῳ, with line-initial ἐν and identically positioned δαπέδῳ. In terms of 'subliminal verbal patterning'[4]) it is noteworthy that the consonantal sequences preceding δαπέδῳ in all of these phrases show phonetically similar inventories, consisting of the voiceless velar stops [k] and [k^h], the sonorants [m], [n], and [r], and the voiceless dentals [t] and [s]; the near phonetic identity of *kouriks* and *khruseôi*, which extends to the nature and sequencing of the non-consonantal segments (here cf. *tuktôi*), is particularly striking.

The status of ὄβριμον, finally, deserves special mention. In Homer, apart from the λίθον ὄβριμον at *Od.* 9.305 (already cited) and a lone line-initial # ὄβριμον· at Od. 9.241, ὄβριμος shows remarkable regularity in its

metrical and formulaic behavior. The remaining twenty-two occurrences (not counting repeated lines) all show the pattern ὄβριμος/ὄβριμον – ⏑̯ # (once with the variant ὄβριμ' ∪ – ⏑̯ #). These can be subdivided, in turn, into two categories, which occur with approximately equal frequency. The first involves ὄβριμος plus the names Ἄρης or Ἕκτωρ (8 ×), cf. the variant ὄβριμ' Ἀχιλλεῦ # *Il.* 19.408. Second, one finds ὄβριμον plus neuter noun (13 ×), of which the phrase ὄβριμον ἔγχος # is the most frequent (11 ×).[5]) The two remaining cases of this type are ὄβριμον ὕδωρ # *Il.* 4.453, and ὄβριμον ἄχθος # *Od.* 9.233, here with the sixth (and deviant) occurrence of ἄχθος, referred to above. This last collocation reveals, finally, the intricacy of the nexus of correspondences underlying *Batr.* 240: the poet has reproduced (whether consciously or not) both the metrical pattern ἄχθος ∪ – ⏑̯ # (in its most frequent incarnation ἄχθος ἀρούρης #), as well as a lexical reminiscence of the unique line-final occurrence of ἄχθος in Homer (with contiguous ὄβριμον, which is nevertheless syntactically unconnected with ἄχθος in *Batr.* 240). We have, then, an associative overlapping 'chain' λίθον ὄβριμον / ὄβριμον ἄχθος / ἄχθος ἀρούρης; each link, moreover, has its own Homeric pedigree of fixed metrical and formulaic behavior. Lastly, it is not without interest that all of the occurrences of ὄβριμος in the *Odyssey* surface within the relatively short span of *Od.* 9.233-305, namely (a) ὄβριμον ἄχθος # (with unique line-final ἄχθος # in Homer), (b) # ὄβριμον· (unique line-initial # ὄβριμος in Homer), and (c) λίθον ὄβριμον (the phrase appearing in *Batr.* 240). The commonplace assumption that the *Batrachomyomachia* shows an "obvious dependence on the *Iliad*"[6]) is clearly correct, *grosso modo*. But Hansjörg Wölke's important discussion of the varied genres in the fabric of the poem[7]) has shown that the literary patrimony of the *Batrachomyomachia* is quite varied; the precise phraseological contributions of works other than the *Iliad* should thus be studied in this light.

The *Batrachomyomachia*, to be sure, is a parodistic pastiche, the literary and comic merits of which are not very highly regarded nowadays, to the extent that they are regarded at all.[8]) But we do not enhance our understanding of the poem merely by disparaging it; specifically, we are not justified in neglecting the interesting stylistic issues the poem raises, many of which concern the precise nature of the poet's imitative and allusive art. Previous analyses have submerged this perspective, in favor of vague and superficial discussions of the mixed 'vocabulary' and 'diction' of the poem. Such treatments are generally used to support dating theories, given alleged Attic or Hellenistic elements in the poem.[9]) But there is so far not the slightest agreement as to the use of such criteria for dating the poem, and I suggest that the real stylistic interest of the *Batrachomyomachia* lies elsewhere.[10]) These remarks on *Batr.* 240 (which is an altogether typical line) show that the imitative and allusive processes at work in the poem, on a minute level of meter and phraseology, are extremely complex. One must emphasize, moreover, that the question of the poet's 'conscious awareness' of the imitative technique just described—however

complex and even systematic that technique may be—is devoid of much interest. Speculative claims as to which 'effects' a poet may have 'intended' grossly devalue and misrepresent the essence of poetic composition, as linguistic poetics has made abundantly clear. For the *Batrachomyomachia*, I hope to have shown that the crude compositional 'grab bag' technique generally imputed to the poem requires serious qualification, leading to a new appreciation not of the poem's stylistic "merits", but of the intricacy and nature of its composition.

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1) Arthur Ludwich, *Die Homerische Batrachomyomachia des Karers Pigres nebst Scholien und Paraphrase* (Leipzig 1896), 396.

2) Ludwich omits, for some reason, reference to the additional line-final occurrence of ἄχθος ἀρούρης # at *Od.* 20.379. (In accordance with linguistic practice, as well as some recent work on Greek poetry, I used the symbol '#' to designate the line-initial or line-final verse boundary.)

3) The variant reading ἐν πεδίῳ, although hardly compelling, has at least some Homeric support; still less likely is the variant ἐν γαίῃ, which according to Ludwich's plausible explanation (ad loc.) is 'aus einer Glosse eingedrungen', cf. Hesych. δάπεδον· ἔδαφος, γῆ.

4) See Roman Jakobson, *Subliminal Verbal Patterning in Poetry*, in: *Studies in General and Oriental Linguistics, presented to Shirô Hattori* (Tokyo 1970), 302-308; reprinted in Jakobson's *Selected Writings III: Poetry of Grammar and Grammar of Poetry* (The Hague-Paris-New York 1981), 136-147. For Homeric diction, note also chapter 4 of D. Gary Miller's *Homer and the Ionian Epic Tradition* (Innsbruck 1982), on "Phonic properties of epic formulas".

5) Here one may note that the line-final ὄβριμον ἄνδρα # at *Batr.* 282 (the only other occurrence of ὄβριμος in the poem) constitutes, in effect, a morphological and semantic conflation of these two subtypes. (Ludwich ad loc. (op. cit. 413) merely cites one of the instances of ὄβριμος Ἕκτωρ, without further comment.)

6) Thus Lawrence J. Bliquez, *Frogs and Mice and Athens*, TAPA 107 (1977), 12.

7) *Untersuchungen zur Batrachomyomachie* (Meisenheim am Glan 1978).

8) Thus, in one of the rare reviews of Wölke's monograph, Ken Dowden, in CR 30 (1980), 136, describes the poem as one of "irredeemable mediocrity". In a similar vein, note Jasper Griffin's slighting stylistic comments on the "banality, inexactness, and repetition" characteristic of the Epic Cycle in general, JHS 97 (1977), 48-52.

9) See e.g. Bliquez (op. cit. n. 6), 12 and 24.

10) For a comprehensive overview of the dating problem, see Wölke (op. cit. n. 7), 46 ff., with detailed analysis of essentially equivocal metrical criteria, 70-84.

PHAIDRA'S RISKY HORSEMANSHIP: EURIPIDES' *HIPPOLYTOS* 232-238

In his commentary, *Euripides. Hippolytos* (Oxford 1964), lines 232-238, W. S. Barrett is puzzled by the use of the words ἀναστρέφειν and παρακόπτειν in the nurse's speech. Phaidra has just revealed an insane passion for